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Othniel

The first of the judges, a proven warrior on whom the Spirit of the LORD came.

Othniel first appears in Caleb's day, capturing Kirjath-sepher and winning Caleb's daughter Achsah as his wife. Years later Israel forgot the LORD, and God gave them into the hand of a foreign king for eight years. When they cried out, God raised up Othniel. The Spirit of the LORD came on him, he judged Israel, went to war, and won. The land had rest forty years. His short story sets the pattern of the book of Judges: sin, oppression, a cry for help, and a deliverer sent by God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Othniel</i> ; meaning uncertain, perhaps "strength of God"
Family	Son of Kenaz, "Caleb's younger brother" (Judges 3:9)
Wife	Achsah, daughter of Caleb (Joshua 15:16–17)
Son	Hathath (1 Chronicles 4:13)
When	The first judge; any BC date is rough
Enemy	Chushan-rishathaim, king of Mesopotamia (Judges 3:8)
Main passages	Joshua 15:13–19; Judges 1:11–15; 3:7–11
New Testament	Not named

"And when the children of Israel cried unto the LORD, the LORD raised up a deliverer to the children of Israel, who delivered them, even Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother."

Judges 3:9, KJV

The life of Othniel

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges ruled c. 1375–1050 BC, and Othniel comes first, so his work probably falls near the start of that span. Treat any date as rough.

In Caleb's day	Takes Kirjath-sepher Caleb promises his daughter to the man who captures Kirjath-sepher, later called Debir. Othniel takes the city and marries Achsah. <i>Joshua 15:15–17; Judges 1:11–13</i>
Soon after	Achsah asks for springs Achsah urges him to ask Caleb for a field. She then asks her father for springs of water, and Caleb gives the upper and nether springs. <i>Joshua 15:18–19; Judges 1:14–15</i>
Eight years	Israel is oppressed Israel forgets the LORD and serves the Baals and the groves. God sells them into the hand of Chushan-rishathaim, and they serve him eight years. <i>Judges 3:7–8</i>
When Israel cries out	Raised up to deliver The Spirit of the LORD comes on Othniel. He judges Israel, goes out to war, and defeats Chushan-rishathaim. <i>Judges 3:9–10</i>
Forty years	Rest and death The land has rest for forty years, and then Othniel dies. <i>Judges 3:11</i>

Group notes

Key activities

"Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother" can be read two ways. Some take Othniel as Caleb's younger brother. Others take Kenaz as the younger brother, which would make Othniel Caleb's nephew. Judges 1:1 also places the capture of Debir after Joshua's death, while Joshua 15 tells it within Caleb's story, and readers explain the order differently.

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- 1 Took a fortified city.** He captured Kirjath-sepher, one of the towns in Caleb's allotment. *Joshua 15:15-17*
 - 2 Married Achsah.** He received Caleb's daughter as the promised reward. *Judges 1:12-13*
 - 3 Received land and water.** With Achsah's help the family gained a field and springs. *Judges 1:14-15*
 - 4 Was filled by the Spirit.** "The Spirit of the LORD came upon him." He is the first judge of whom this is said. *Judges 3:10*
 - 5 Judged Israel.** He led the people before he led them in battle. *Judges 3:10*
 - 6 Defeated a foreign king.** "His hand prevailed against Chushan-rishathaim." *Judges 3:10*
 - 7 Brought rest.** The land had rest forty years while he lived. *Judges 3:11*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Othniel.

Old Testament

Joshua 15:15–19; Judges 1:11–15	He takes Kirjath-sepher and marries Achsah
Judges 3:7–11	His time as judge, the book's first full pattern
1 Chronicles 4:13	Named with his son Hathath
1 Chronicles 27:15	Heldai, David's commander, "of Othniel," probably a descendant
Echo: Numbers 14:24; Joshua 14:6–14	Caleb's faith carried on in his family
Echo: Judges 6:34; 11:29; 14:6	The Spirit later comes on other judges

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:68–71	God again raises up a deliverer for his people
Echo: Hebrews 11:32–34	Judges who "out of weakness were made strong"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What four things does Judges 3:10 say happened when the Spirit of the LORD came on Othniel?
2. *Understand:* Othniel had already proved himself in battle years before. Why do you think God chose someone with that history?
3. *Apply:* Judges 2:10 describes a generation that "knew not the LORD." What can you do to pass on faith to the next generation?
4. *Apply:* Israel cried out after eight years. Is there an area of your life where you need to stop struggling alone and cry out to God?